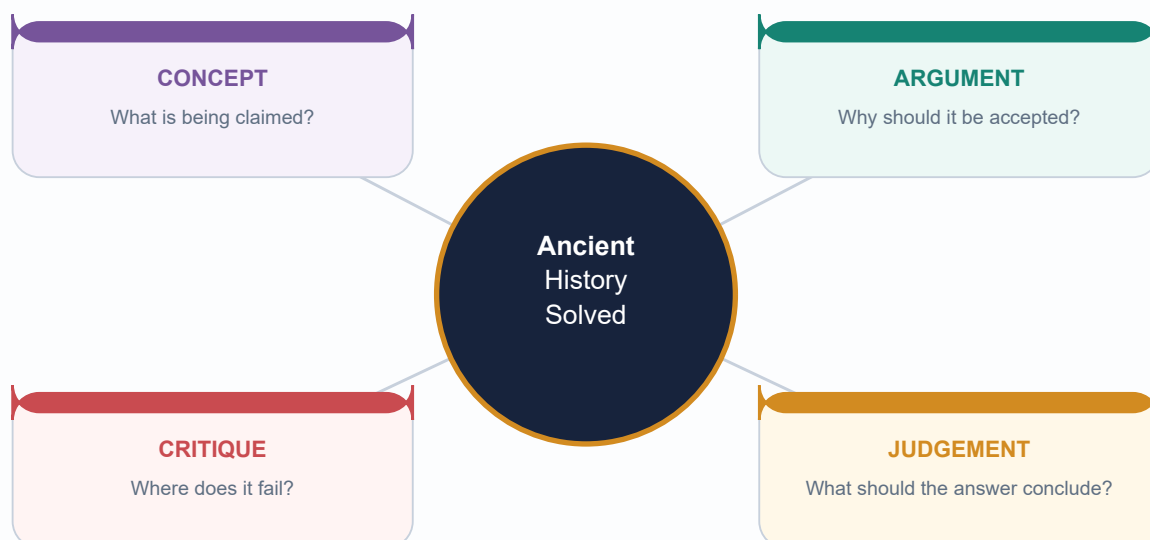


## SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

# Ancient History 19 - Solved Practice Workbook

4 routed PYQs | 32 broad MCQs | 8 remedials | 6 solved Mains  
Original MCQ keys rotate A-B-C-D in each intended sequence  
Inferred, official and provisional PYQ statuses remain explicit



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

## HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

## 01. Workbook method and PYQ ownership

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

[FACT] The workbook contains four locally routed Prelims PYQs, 32 broad original MCQs, eight remedials and six solved Mains questions.

## STATIC THEORY

- [LIMIT] No directly owned Mains PYQ was located in the audited local ledgers.
- [FACT] Original MCQs rotate A-B-C-D strictly across the 32-question broad sequence and again across the eight-question remedial sequence.
- [LIMIT] Actual PYQ answer letters are preserved and are not altered to fit rotation.

## MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 2020 keys inferred; 2025 key official locally; 2026 key provisional.

## UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Provisional or inferred means official.

**CORRECT:** Status labels remain visible.

## MAINS ANGLE

Use explanations for elimination practice.

## STUDY LINK

Local routing ledgers.

HIGH

## 02. Solved verified/routed Prelims PYQs

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

[FACT] Wording is taken from the locally held papers or their audited neutral rendering; ownership is labelled.

## STATIC THEORY

- UPSC Prelims 2020 Q25 - adjacent chronological owner. Question: Which phrase defines the nature of the 'Hundi' generally referred to in sources of the post-Harsha period? Options included an advisory, a daily-account diary, a bill of exchange, and a feudal order. Solution: Answer: bill of exchange (option C in the locally held paper). [FACT] A hundi was a credit/remittance instrument, not a coin. [LIMIT] This PYQ concerns the post-Harsha period and is included only because the local routing ledger assigns it to Topic 19; it must not be back-projected as a fully developed instrument in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Key status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - official 2020 key not held locally.

- UPSC Prelims 2020 Q82 - adjacent Gupta-period owner. Question: With reference to the Gupta period, Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were known as what? Options included ports handling foreign trade, capitals, stone-art centres and Buddhist pilgrimage centres. Solution: Answer: ports handling foreign trade (option A in the locally held paper). [ANALYSIS] The question tests continuity and relocation of maritime nodes beyond Topic 19's core window. [LIMIT] It is not evidence that every named port peaked before 250 CE. Key status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - official 2020 key not held locally.

- UPSC Prelims 2025 Q13 - adjacent technology route. Question: The irrigation device called Araghatta was: leather bag over a pulley; large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes; large earthen pot driven by bullocks; or hand-pulled bucket. Solution: Answer: a large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes (option B; official Set-A key is held locally). [LIMIT] The local canonical file places the term cautiously and notes that its exact earliest attestation is debated; it is not a core craft-commerce institution of 200 BCE-250 CE. Key status: OFFICIALLY KEYED LOCALLY.

- UPSC Prelims 2026 routed question - direct money-economy demand. Question: Pali texts contain definite coin references such as kahapana, nikkha, kamsa and kakanika; archaeological punch-marked coins, mostly silver, corroborate the literary evidence. With which developments are these statements associated: emergence of urban life and/or transition to money economy? Solution: Answer: both emergence of urban life and transition to money economy (option C in the locally held provisional Set-A material). The textual-archaeological pairing is the key: terminology alone is not enough, and punch-marked finds alone do not reveal every monetary practice. Key status: PROVISIONAL 2026 KEY - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

### MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Hundi = bill of exchange.
2. Ghantasala/Kadura/Chaul = foreign-trade ports.
3. Araghatta = wheel with earthen pots.
4. Pali evidence supports urban and money transitions.

### UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Back-project later Hundi evidence.  
**CORRECT:** Keep it post-Harsha.

### MAINS ANGLE

*Convert objective distinctions into source-aware notes.*

### STUDY LINK

PYQ ledgers.

HIGH

## 03. Broad MCQs 1-8

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

### INTRO & ORIGIN

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A-B-C-D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

### STATIC THEORY

- Q1. Which statement best captures the relation between second urbanisation and c. 200 BCE-250 CE growth? A) Post-Mauryan growth intensified an older urban base but followed regionally different paths B) Towns first appeared only after 200 BCE C) Only overseas trade created towns D) The Deccan copied one Ganga model unchanged

- Answer: A. The correct frame is continuity plus intensification, with regional variation.

- Q2. Which evidence most directly supports specialised textile processing at Arikamedu and Uraiyur? A) Roman coins B) Brick-built dyeing vats C) Ring wells D) Royal prashastis
- Answer: B. Dyeing vats are production installations; coins or ring wells are indirect.
- Q3. A mould producing repeated objects most safely indicates: A) State monopoly B) Hereditary caste closure C) Batch production or standardisation D) Export to Rome
- Answer: C. Moulds show repeatability, not ownership, labour status or destination.
- Q4. Which is the strongest caution about occupational clustering in a village? A) It proves no specialisation B) It proves all workers were slaves C) It proves the settlement was a capital D) It does not by itself prove guild membership or hereditary closure
- Answer: D. Residence pattern, corporate membership and social status are distinct questions.
- Q5. The Ahichchhatra expression kumhakara seniya is linked with: A) A potters' guild B) A royal mint C) A caravan tax D) A monastic council
- Answer: A. The seal is used as evidence for a potters' corporate body.
- Q6. Why are Maharashtra guild deposits significant? A) They prove universal banking B) They show corporate bodies entrusted with recurring religious provision C) They prove state ownership of guilds D) They establish uniform interest rates
- Answer: B. Deposits show trust and endowment roles, but not a full modern banking system.
- Q7. The route Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch primarily illustrates: A) A Gupta pilgrimage circuit B) A single Roman military road C) An inland corridor linking the north-west to a western port D) A purely coastal route
- Answer: C. It connects inland nodes to Bharuch; route lines remain schematic.
- Q8. Which statement about caravans is least defensible? A) They moved inland goods B) They could pool risk and transport C) Sangam material mentions chattu D) One uniform empire-wide caravan organisation is fully documented
- Answer: D. Evidence supports caravans, not a standard pan-Indian corporate form.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Q1 key A: The correct frame is continuity plus intensification, with regional variation.
2. Q2 key B: Dyeing vats are production installations; coins or ring wells are indirect.
3. Q3 key C: Moulds show repeatability, not ownership, labour status or destination.
4. Q4 key D: Residence pattern, corporate membership and social status are distinct questions.
5. Q5 key A: The seal is used as evidence for a potters' corporate body.
6. Q6 key B: Deposits show trust and endowment roles, but not a full modern banking system.
7. Q7 key C: It connects inland nodes to Bharuch; route lines remain schematic.
8. Q8 key D: Evidence supports caravans, not a standard pan-Indian corporate form.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Memorise the option letter.

**CORRECT:** Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

**MAINS ANGLE**

*Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.*

**STUDY LINK**

Topic 19 learning session.

HIGH

## 04. Broad MCQs 9-16

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A-B-C-D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

## STATIC THEORY

- Q9. A port-hinterland approach begins with: A) Agrarian and craft supply feeding the port B) Imported amphorae alone C) Foreign colonies D) Royal capitals only

- Answer: A. Ports depended on production, transport and inland consumption.

- Q10. Which is the safest statement about the monsoon and maritime trade? A) A single foreign sailor taught India sea travel B) Seasonal wind knowledge enabled direct crossings within long-evolving Indian Ocean expertise C) Monsoon sailing eliminated coastal trade D) It began only after 300 CE

- Answer: B. Avoid the one-discoverer myth and preserve accumulated regional knowledge.

- Q11. Pliny's complaint about bullion outflow is best used as: A) A precise trade-balance statistic B) Proof of Roman rule in India C) Evidence of Roman anxiety about luxury imports D) Proof that only pepper was traded

- Answer: C. It is rhetorical evidence, not a quantified balance sheet.

- Q12. Amphorae at an Indian site do NOT by themselves prove: A) Mediterranean-linked contact B) Imported container circulation C) Elite consumption possibilities D) A resident Roman colony

- Answer: D. Material contact and resident ethnicity are separate claims.

- Q13. Which pairing is correct? A) Ujjain - agate and carnelian bead work B) Taxila - Tamil pearl fishery C) Mathura - Malabar pepper port D) Tamralipti - north-western caravan capital

- Answer: A. Ujjain was a route junction and bead-working centre.

- Q14. Kushana coinage is especially associated with: A) Only lead issues B) Gold and abundant copper denominations C) No legends D) Roman imperial portraits only

- Answer: B. Kushanas issued both high-value gold and low-denomination copper.

- Q15. Why is gold coinage an incomplete measure of monetisation? A) Gold never circulated B) Coins were only ritual C) Everyday exchange could use lower denominations, kind or barter D) Gold is archaeologically invisible

- Answer: C. Different transaction scales used different media.

- Q16. Which conclusion from city coins is excessive? A) Urban authorities could issue coins B) Cities had political-economic identities C) Coinage can reveal institutions D) Every city had sovereign independence

- Answer: D. Issuing authority does not automatically equal full sovereignty.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Q9 key A: Ports depended on production, transport and inland consumption.
2. Q10 key B: Avoid the one-discoverer myth and preserve accumulated regional knowledge.
3. Q11 key C: It is rhetorical evidence, not a quantified balance sheet.
4. Q12 key D: Material contact and resident ethnicity are separate claims.
5. Q13 key A: Ujjain was a route junction and bead-working centre.
6. Q14 key B: Kushanas issued both high-value gold and low-denomination copper.
7. Q15 key C: Different transaction scales used different media.
8. Q16 key D: Issuing authority does not automatically equal full sovereignty.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Memorise the option letter.

**CORRECT:** Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

**MAINS ANGLE**

Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

**STUDY LINK**

Topic 19 learning session.

**HIGH****05. Broad MCQs 17-24**

**GS-I / Prelims**  
Ancient Indian  
History

**INTRO & ORIGIN**

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A-B-C-D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

**STATIC THEORY**

- Q17. Which cluster most strongly supports an urban interpretation? A) Fortification, planned streets, drains, coins and craft debris together B) One imported sherd C) One literary mention D) One gold coin outside context

- Answer: A. Urbanism is inferred from converging indicators.

- Q18. Taxila's Sirkap is notable for: A) Only cave monasteries B) Orderly street layout, fortifications and courtyard houses C) A Chola dockyard D) No evidence of shops

- Answer: B. Its morphology shows planned and differentiated urban space.

- Q19. Which statement about ring wells is correct? A) They prove a metropolis B) They are always ritual C) They are one water/sanitation indicator requiring context D) They occur only in Tamilakam

- Answer: C. A ring well is useful but not sufficient for urban classification.

- Q20. Which city should NOT be reduced to a single political-capital function? A) Mathura B) Ujjain C) Taxila D) All of these

- Answer: D. Each combined route, craft, sacred, market or political roles.

- Q21. Paithan and Tagara are best placed in: A) Inland Deccan commercial networks B) The lower Indus delta C) The middle Ganga NBPW core only D) Roman Italy

- Answer: A. They connected Deccan production to western and other routes.

- Q22. Arikamedu is best described as: A) A securely proven Roman colony B) An early historic settlement with craft and Mediterranean-linked trade evidence C) Only a Buddhist pilgrimage site D) A Gupta capital

- Answer: B. Settlement chronology and material contact are real; colony language overstates.
- Q23. Urban-rural interdependence means: A) Villages only supplied tax B) Towns were self-sufficient C) Two-way flows linked food/raw materials with tools, markets and institutions D) Cities replaced agriculture
- Answer: C. The relationship involved production, demand and redistribution in both directions.
- Q24. Which claim about commercial mobility is excessive? A) Donors gained visibility B) Corporate identity could create standing C) Merchants could acquire prestige D) Commerce abolished hierarchy
- Answer: D. Commercial wealth complicated but did not erase social hierarchy.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Q17 key A: Urbanism is inferred from converging indicators.
2. Q18 key B: Its morphology shows planned and differentiated urban space.
3. Q19 key C: A ring well is useful but not sufficient for urban classification.
4. Q20 key D: Each combined route, craft, sacred, market or political roles.
5. Q21 key A: They connected Deccan production to western and other routes.
6. Q22 key B: Settlement chronology and material contact are real; colony language overstates.
7. Q23 key C: The relationship involved production, demand and redistribution in both directions.
8. Q24 key D: Commercial wealth complicated but did not erase social hierarchy.

**UPSC TRAPS****WRONG:** Memorise the option letter.**CORRECT:** Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.**MAINS ANGLE***Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 19 learning session.

**HIGH****06. Broad MCQs 25-32**
**GS-I / Prelims**  
 Ancient Indian  
 History
**INTRO & ORIGIN**

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A-B-C-D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

**STATIC THEORY**

- Q25. Buddhist cave donations most directly reveal: A) A diverse donor world including merchants and artisans B) Monastic control of every route C) Absence of royal donors D) No economic role for religion
- Answer: A. They connect religious patronage with multiple social groups.
- Q26. Which formulation is safest? A) Buddhism was only a merchant religion B) Monasteries were religious institutions embedded in economic landscapes C) Monks were customs officials D) All guilds were Buddhist
- Answer: B. Economic embeddedness should not reduce religion to commerce.
- Q27. The state-commerce relationship is best understood as: A) State ownership of all trade B) No political role C) Enabling, extracting and participating in varying combinations D) Uniform free trade
- Answer: C. Security, tolls, coinage and infrastructure could help or burden exchange.

- Q28. Which statement is least defensible? A) Kushana power affected route security B) Tamil rulers levied tolls/customs C) Satavahana networks linked interiors and coasts D) Political unity was necessary for all trade
- Answer: D. Trade also crossed political boundaries and survived divided sovereignty.
- Q29. What is the strongest first step in a decline answer? A) Separate site-specific decline from wider transformation B) Blame Rome alone C) Assume all towns vanished in 250 CE D) Ignore archaeology
- Answer: A. Define the spatial and evidentiary scope before explaining causes.
- Q30. Which factor should qualify the Roman-trade decline thesis? A) No internal trade existed B) Internal, eastern and regional networks could continue C) Coins never changed D) Ports had no hinterlands
- Answer: B. A contraction in one circuit need not end all exchange.
- Q31. A north-Deccan-deep south comparison should emphasise: A) One uniform chronology B) Only dynastic lists C) Different evidence combinations and pathways D) No interaction between regions
- Answer: C. Comparison requires both regional specificity and interconnection.
- Q32. A high-scoring verdict should avoid: A) Named evidence B) Regional qualification C) Causal linkage D) A single-cause claim that foreign trade created and destroyed all towns
- Answer: D. The process was multi-causal and uneven.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Q25 key A: They connect religious patronage with multiple social groups.
2. Q26 key B: Economic embeddedness should not reduce religion to commerce.
3. Q27 key C: Security, tolls, coinage and infrastructure could help or burden exchange.
4. Q28 key D: Trade also crossed political boundaries and survived divided sovereignty.
5. Q29 key A: Define the spatial and evidentiary scope before explaining causes.
6. Q30 key B: A contraction in one circuit need not end all exchange.
7. Q31 key C: Comparison requires both regional specificity and interconnection.
8. Q32 key D: The process was multi-causal and uneven.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Memorise the option letter.

**CORRECT:** Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

**MAINS ANGLE**

Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

**STUDY LINK**

Topic 19 learning session.

**HIGH****07. Remedial MCQs 1-8**

**GS-I / Prelims**  
Ancient Indian  
History

**INTRO & ORIGIN**

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A-B-C-D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

**STATIC THEORY**

- Q1. Roman coins at a site prove first and foremost: A) Contact, bullion flow or circulation in context B) A Roman colony C) Roman sovereignty D) Latin-speaking majority



- Answer: A. Start with the narrowest evidence-safe inference.
- Q2. A guild deposit proves: A) Uniform interest law B) Entrusted corporate endowment activity C) Modern deposit insurance D) Royal ownership
- Answer: B. The record supports custody/income provision, not a modern system.
- Q3. Uttarapatha should be treated as: A) One surviving paved road B) A coastal shipping lane C) A broad and changing northern corridor/network D) A Gupta-only term
- Answer: C. Do not turn a route concept into one immutable line.
- Q4. One coin hoard cannot by itself establish: A) Coin presence B) Metal composition C) A chronological clue D) Total regional prosperity
- Answer: D. Prosperity needs settlement and production evidence too.
- Q5. The safest description of Pattanam is: A) A strong but debated Muziris identification B) Secure Roman colony C) Gupta capital D) Inland Kushana mint
- Answer: A. Keep the identification debate visible.
- Q6. Araghatta belongs in this package mainly as: A) Proof of Roman technology B) An adjacent routed PYQ with chronology caution C) A guild office D) A coin type
- Answer: B. It is included because the local ledger routes it here.
- Q7. Hundi should be described as: A) A c. 200 BCE coin B) A Roman amphora C) A post-Harsha credit/bill-of-exchange concept, not back-projected D) A Satavahana tax
- Answer: C. Respect the later chronological owner.
- Q8. The best decline conclusion is: A) All cities vanished B) Rome alone caused collapse C) Trade ended permanently D) Urban systems transformed unevenly across regions
- Answer: D. Use decline only where site evidence supports it.

**MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Q1 key A: Start with the narrowest evidence-safe inference.
2. Q2 key B: The record supports custody/income provision, not a modern system.
3. Q3 key C: Do not turn a route concept into one immutable line.
4. Q4 key D: Prosperity needs settlement and production evidence too.
5. Q5 key A: Keep the identification debate visible.
6. Q6 key B: It is included because the local ledger routes it here.
7. Q7 key C: Respect the later chronological owner.
8. Q8 key D: Use decline only where site evidence supports it.

**UPSC TRAPS**

**WRONG:** Memorise the option letter.

**CORRECT:** Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

**MAINS ANGLE**

*Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.*

**STUDY LINK**

Topic 19 learning session.

HIGH

## 08. Solved 10-mark questions

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

[ANALYSIS] Two 150-word models with compact evidence density.

## STATIC THEORY

- 10 marks / 150 words - Explain how agrarian surplus and craft specialisation reinforced early historic urban growth. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Early historic towns were concentrations of non-food-producing groups, so urban growth required a productive countryside and mechanisms for converting surplus into specialised output. First, diversified agriculture supplied food and raw materials. [FACT] Sanghol's early-centuries-CE plant record includes cereals, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, spices and a dye plant; Deccan evidence supports cotton and paddy expansion. This sustained consumers and fed textile and dyeing chains. Second, specialisation multiplied value. [FACT] Ujjain's agate-carnelian working, Arikamedu/Uraiyur dyeing vats and Telangana iron artefacts show regionally distinct production. Third, towns and routes concentrated demand, exchange and skills, while moulds and repeated forms suggest batch production. [LIMIT] Surplus did not automatically create cities: political security, transport, institutions and market demand remained necessary, and site evidence is uneven. Thus agrarian production and craft specialisation formed a reciprocal rather than one-way urban system. Why this earns marks: It gives a direct causal thesis, four named evidence units, explains significance and ends with a qualification.

- 10 marks / 150 words - Distinguish evidence for guild corporate identity from claims about modern banking. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Shrenis were occupational corporate bodies, but equating them with modern banks overstates the evidence. [FACT] The Ahichchhatra kumhakra seniya seal records a potters' guild; another sealing may refer to arrowhead/spearhead makers. These establish corporate identity. [FACT] Second-century-CE Maharashtra records entrusted money with potter, oil-miller and weaver guilds to provide monastic necessities, while a Mathura flour-makers' deposit funded recurring Brahmana service. These show reputation, custody and income-bearing endowment functions. [ANALYSIS] Such arrangements reduced continuity risk by attaching obligations to a body rather than an individual. [LIMIT] The records do not establish universal deposits, regulated reserves, negotiable instruments, deposit insurance or uniform interest rates. Nigama coins similarly indicate limited merchant authority, not sovereignty. Therefore 'financial intermediary' or 'endowment custodian' is safer than 'bank'. Why this earns marks: It distinguishes concepts, names three records, explains institutional significance and explicitly controls analogy.

## MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Direct thesis; 2-3 precise examples; one explicit limit.

## UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Use a 20-mark structure for 10 marks.**CORRECT:** Prioritise the causal core and concise qualification.

## MAINS ANGLE

Rewrite each in 7 minutes.

## STUDY LINK

Production and guild sections.

HIGH

## 09. Solved 15-mark questions

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

## INTRO &amp; ORIGIN

[ANALYSIS] Two 250-word models requiring relationship and critical assessment.

## STATIC THEORY

- 15 marks / 250 words - Examine the relationship between internal trade routes and overseas exchange in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Overseas exchange was the seaward extension of inland production and redistribution, not an autonomous 'Roman trade' enclave. [FACT] The Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch corridor linked the north-west and Malwa to a western port; Ujjain also received the Kaushambi route and worked agate-carnelian beads. [FACT] Deccan nodes such as Paithan and Tagara channelled agrarian and craft goods towards western and southern outlets. Sangam chattu caravans carried paddy, salt and pepper, showing inland movement behind coastal trade. At ports, [FACT] Bharuch, Muziris, Arikamedu, Puhar and Tamralipti aggregated goods, collected customs, enabled shipping and redistributed imports. Mediterranean-linked exchange moved pepper, textiles, beads, pearls, stones, ivory and iron/steel outward, while coins/bullion, amphorae, ceramics, glass and metals came inward. [ANALYSIS] Ports therefore depended on hinterland routes, while overseas demand could deepen selected craft specialisation and urban consumption. State security under Kushana and Satavahana polities and local toll/custom arrangements affected transaction costs. [LIMIT] Route maps are reconstructions, not fixed highways; imported ceramics do not prove foreign colonies; and luxury trade did not replace internal or subsistence exchange. The relationship was nested: village and craft cluster to market node, route junction, port and multi-nodal Indian Ocean circuit. Why this earns marks: It answers relationship rather than listing routes, uses six named nodes and goods, and qualifies maps, colony claims and trade composition.

- 15 marks / 250 words - Critically assess coinage as evidence for monetisation and prosperity. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Coinage is indispensable evidence for authority, exchange and connectivity, but it is not a self-sufficient index of prosperity. [FACT] Indo-Greek bilingual and bi-script issues illuminate rulers otherwise poorly known; Kushanas issued gold and abundant copper; Satavahanas used silver, copper, lead and potin; Tamil dynastic issues and Roman-linked coins widened the peninsular record. [FACT] City coins from Ujjayini, Kaushambi, Vidisha, Varanasi and Taxila and a few negama issues reveal civic and corporate authority. Coin moulds at sites such as Sunet demonstrate minting activity, while Pali terms such as kahapana and kakanika are corroborated by punch-marked silver finds. These data show multiple denominations, issuers and transaction spheres. Yet [LIMIT] hoards may represent savings, crisis concealment or bullion rather than routine market use; gold was unsuitable for most small transactions; coin survival is shaped by metal and excavation; and barter, kind payments and customary obligations continued. Roman coins may have circulated, been valued as bullion, imitated or counter-struck, so their exact use needs context. [ANALYSIS] Prosperity should therefore be tested through coinage plus settlement expansion, craft debris, inscriptions, route evidence and consumption patterns. Coinage demonstrates monetisation's reach and political symbolism, not a universal cash economy or ancient GDP. Why this earns marks: It balances six coin classes with four methodological limits and provides a clear corroboration protocol.

### MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Use 4-6 examples and a clear counterpoint.

### UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Route list without relationship.

**CORRECT:** Show how inland, port and overseas levels connect.

### MAINS ANGLE

Rewrite each in 11 minutes.

### STUDY LINK

Routes and coinage sections.

## MEDIUM UPSC RELEVANCE

MEDIUM

## 10. Solved 20-mark questions

GS-I / Prelims  
Ancient Indian  
History

### INTRO & ORIGIN

[ANALYSIS] Two synthesis models integrate the whole topic and regional comparison.

## STATIC THEORY

- 20 marks / 250 words - 'Crafts, commerce and urban growth formed a mutually reinforcing system in post-Mauryan India.' Critically discuss. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] The proposition is persuasive if treated as a networked, regionally uneven process rooted in an older agrarian-urban base. Production came first but was not isolated. [FACT] Sanghol's diversified crop record and Deccan cotton/paddy evidence supplied food and fibre; Ujjain bead working, Telangana iron, Arikamedu/Uraiyur dyeing vats, ivory, glass, pottery and coin moulds show specialised manufacture. Commerce connected these clusters. [FACT] Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch and Kaushambi-Ujjain corridors, Paithan-Tagara routes and Sangam caravans linked hinterlands to ports. Institutions reduced continuity and trust problems: [FACT] potter, oil-miller, weaver and flour-maker bodies received deposits for recurring religious provision; merchant and artisan donors appear at western Deccan caves. Coinage widened transaction options through Kushana gold/copper, Satavahana multi-metal issues, civic coins and Roman-linked bullion. Urban nodes concentrated consumers, workshops, rulers and religious establishments. [FACT] Sirkap's streets, fortifications, courtyard houses and possible shops, and Hastinapura's bricks, ring well, tools, beads and coins illustrate functional concentration. The loop was reinforcing: urban demand deepened crafts, commerce expanded markets, and surplus sustained non-producers. [LIMIT] It was not automatic or uniform. Guild evidence is local, monetisation incomplete, imported ceramics do not prove colonies, and foreign luxury trade cannot explain every town. From the third century, some regions contracted while others transformed, reflecting political and route change as well as overseas demand. The system therefore explains a major early-historic florescence, but only through regional comparison and source triangulation. Why this earns marks: It integrates production, institutions, routes, coins, morphology and decline with more than eight named evidence units and sustained qualification.

- 20 marks / 250 words - Compare the urban-commercial trajectories of north India, the Deccan and the deep south in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] The three zones participated in interconnected early-historic growth, but their starting points, evidence and political forms differed. North India built on the second-urbanisation legacy of NBPW, punch-marked coins and Ganga towns. [FACT] Taxila's successive cities, Mathura's route-religious-craft role, Ujjain's bead industry and junction position, and burnt-brick/ring-well levels at Hastinapura show established urban continuity intensified under Indo-Greek, Shaka and Kushana contexts. The Deccan combined agrarian expansion with inland-coastal routes and religious patronage. [FACT] Satavahana multi-metal coinage, Paithan and Tagara, western Deccan cave donors, guild deposits in Maharashtra and lower-Krishna centres such as Amaravati reveal a network polity and commercial landscape. The deep south grew from megalithic and chiefly backgrounds into literate port-centred systems. [FACT] Tamil-Brahmi at craft and Red Sea-linked sites, dynastic coins, Sangam caravans, Uraiyur dyeing, Arikamedu craft/import evidence and Muziris/Puhar traditions show production and maritime integration. [ANALYSIS] North India's route cities were more closely tied to older urban sequences; Deccan growth joined plateau interiors to two coasts; deep-south centres reveal strong port and literary visibility alongside emerging state structures. [LIMIT] These are tendencies, not sealed regions: routes and commodities crossed them, excavation is unequal, Sangam texts were later compiled, Pattanam-Muziris remains debated and dynastic archaeological labels can mislead. Thus comparison should recognise shared drivers - surplus, crafts, routes, institutions and coinage - while preserving distinct regional chronologies and evidence profiles. Why this earns marks: It uses a consistent comparative framework, gives named evidence in all three regions and avoids both uniformity and isolation.

### MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Use 5-8+ evidence units and a graded verdict.

### UPSC TRAPS

**WRONG:** Foreign trade monocause.

**CORRECT:** Integrate production, institutions, circulation and regional limits.

### MAINS ANGLE

Rewrite each in 14 minutes.

### STUDY LINK

Historiography and answer architecture.